Meetings—an essential form of communication

- **Necessary in every profession**

- **Organizing and running meetings**

1) When it is useful to have a meeting in the first place?

a) Generally, work best to create a consensus on some issue where the possible solutions have already been carefully narrowed down

b) Do not work for brainstorming or other situations where the group is just beginning to think about a problem.

c) Before calling a meeting, first ask yourself "What do I hope to get out of it?"

If you decide to call the meeting

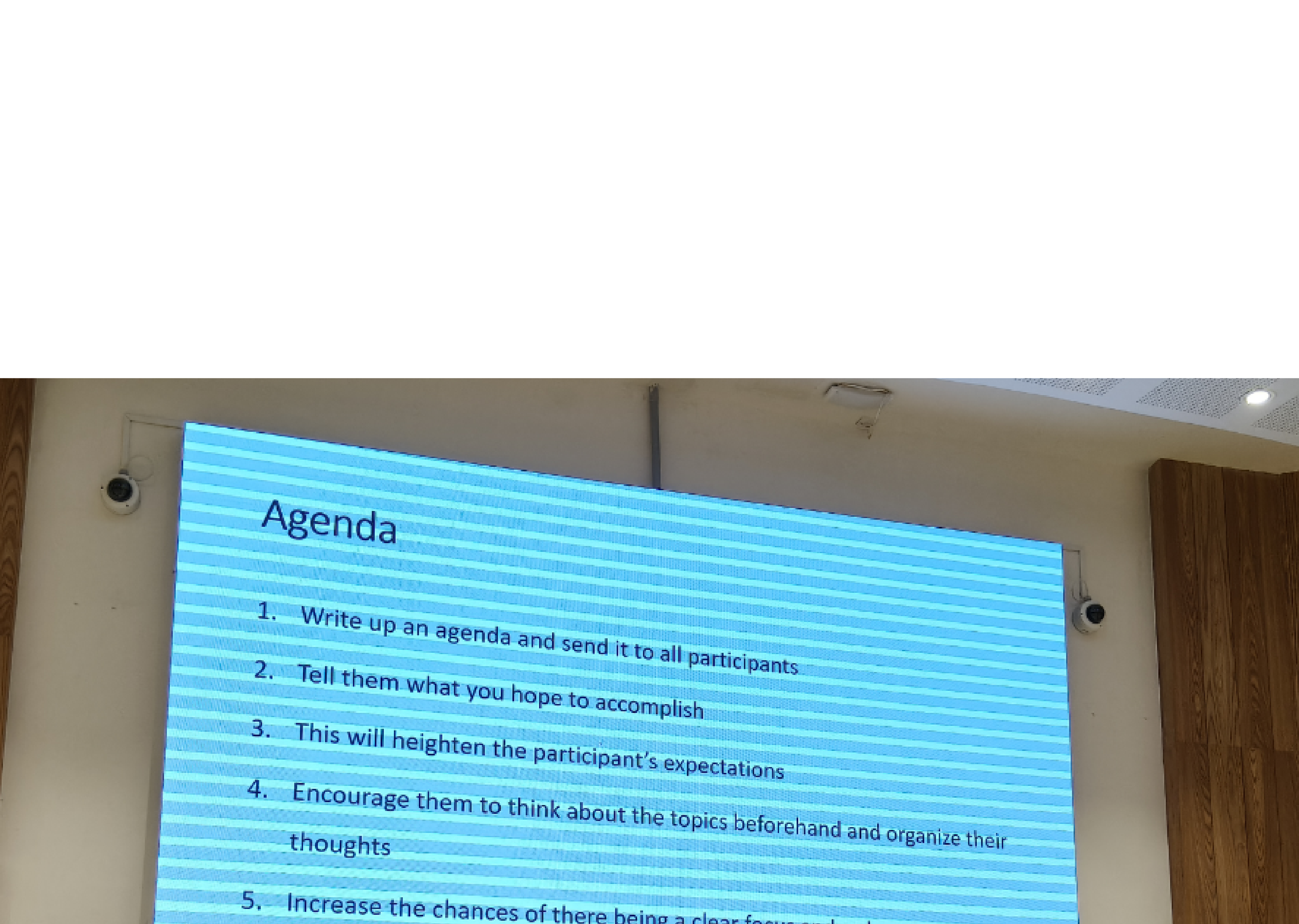
1) Give yourself adequate time to prepare for it

2) Decide who you want to invite to the meeting

3) Include only those who will contribute to it

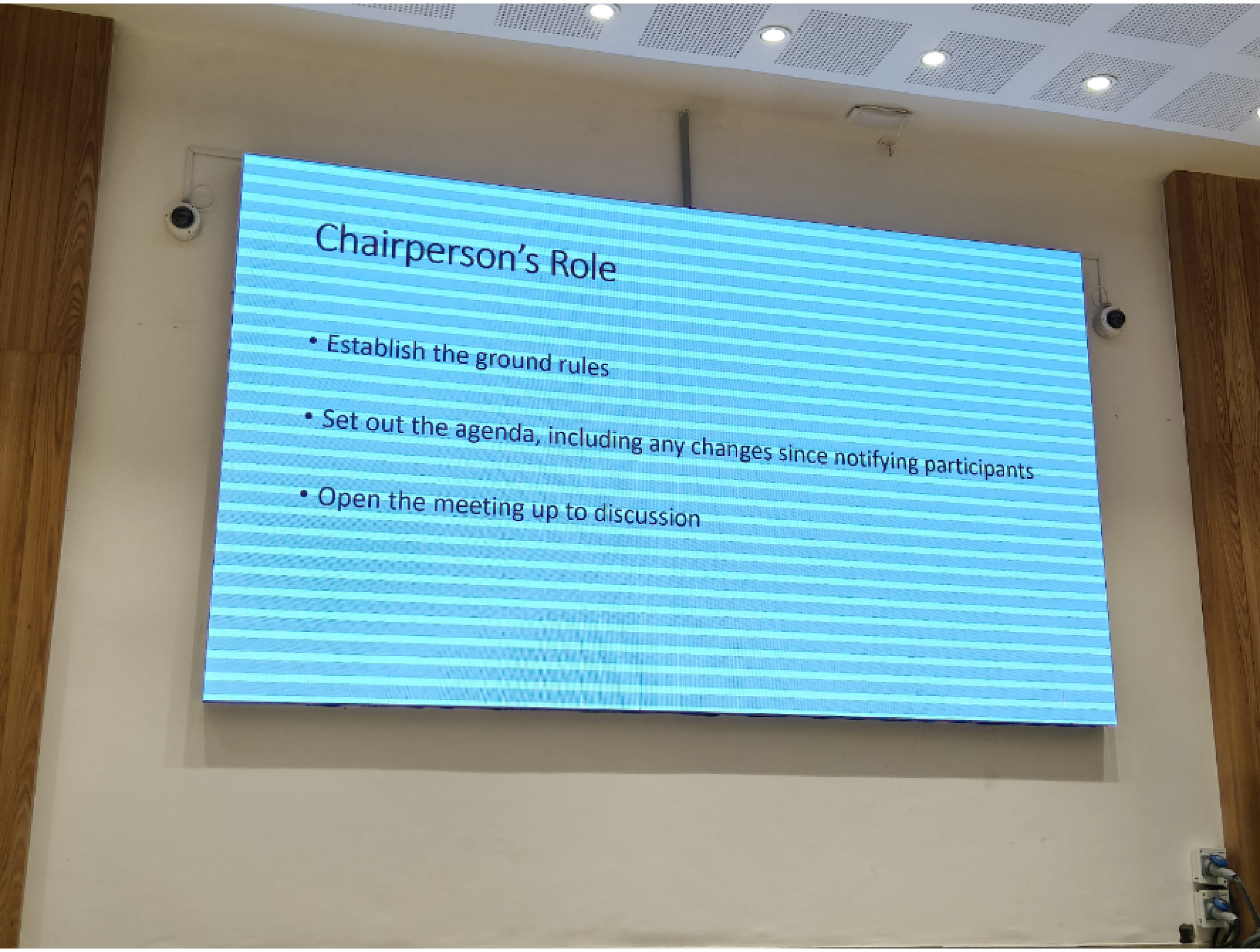
4) Do not include those who are likely to pursue their own agendas and disrupt yours

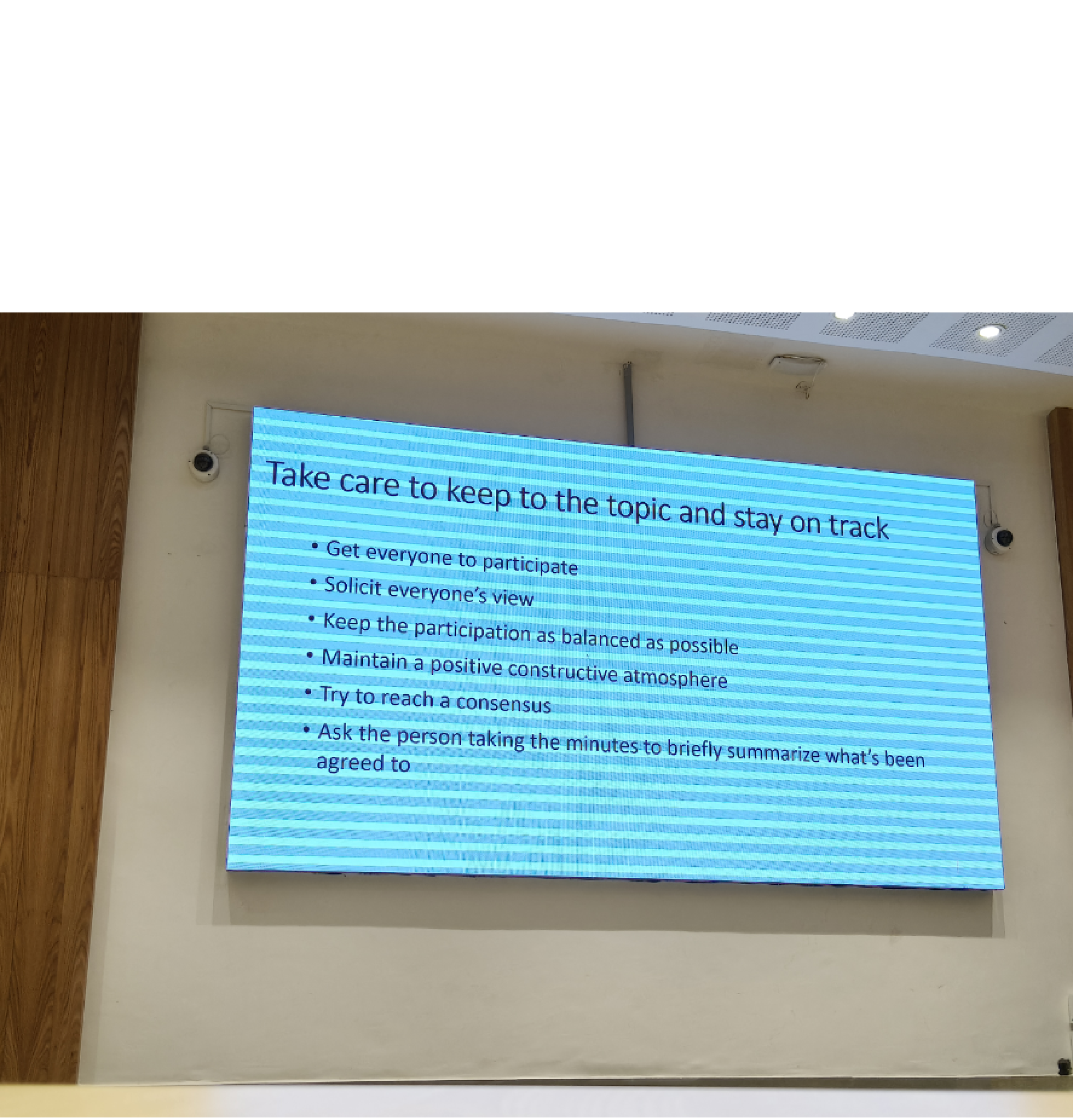
5) Do not include those who have nothing to say


Agenda
1. Write up an agenda and send it to all participants
2. Tell them what you hope to accomplish
3. This will heighten the participant's expectations
4. Encourage them to think about the topics beforehand and organize their thoughts
5. Increase the chances of there being a clear focus and a clear outcome

Time and Space

- Decide on an appropriate time and place
- If possible, hold it at a time when people are likely to be most alert
- Room you chose should be conducive: comfortable, well- lit, quiet
- Should be free from distractions: phone calls, garish artwork, maintenance workers, and so on


Chairperson’s Role
• Establish the ground rules
• Set out the agenda, including any changes since notifying participants
• Open the meeting up to discussion


Take care to keep to the topic and stay on track
• Get everyone to participate
• Solicit everyone's view
• Keep the participation as balanced as possible
• Maintain a positive constructive atmosphere
• Try to reach a consensus
• Ask the person taking the minutes to briefly summarize what's been agreed to

Minutes of Meetings (crucial for later reporting)

- The minutes should be taken by some one other than the Chairperson of the meeting
- A minute taker should be identified well in advance
- Short action minutes are generally most appropriate
- Action minutes eliminate confusion and serve as the basis for appropriate follow-up

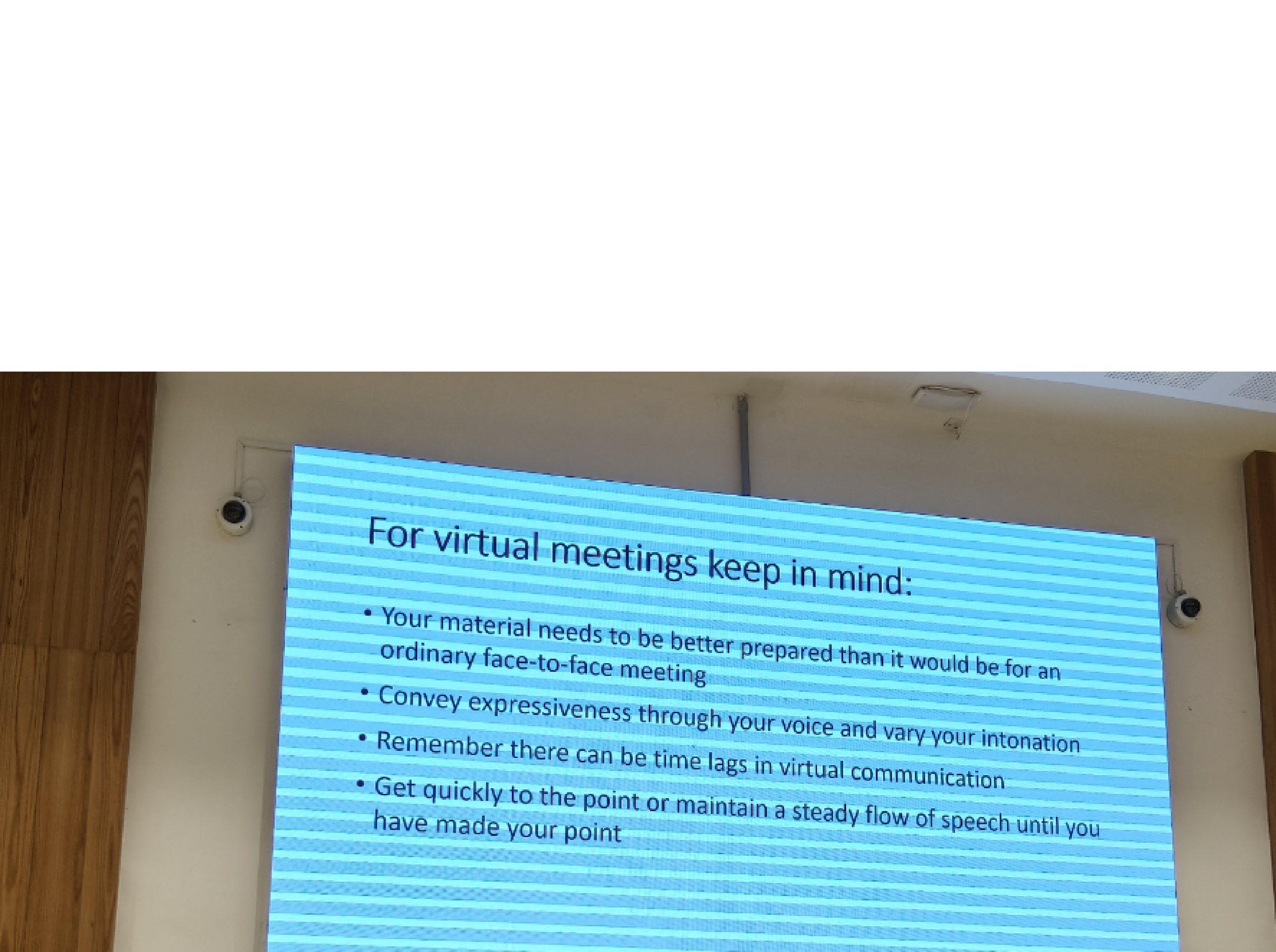
Tele and Video Conferencing

Major Advantage

- It eliminates travel
- It can focus effectively on problem-solving activities
- No less effective in the accuracy of information
- Transmitted/in the amount of time required to transmit that information

Disadvantages

- Nonverbal communication do not get focus
- They do not serve social bonding as well as physical meetings
- They are complicated to set up technically
- They require special preparation and special presentation skills on the part of the participants


For virtual meetings keep in mind:
• Your material needs to be better prepared than it would be for an ordinary face-to-face meeting
• Convey expressiveness through your voice and vary your intonation
• Remember there can be time lags in virtual communication
• Get quickly to the point or maintain a steady flow of speech until you have made your point

Resume, Statement of Purpose, and Job Application, Memos

- **It is difficult to prepare a good resume and a good cover letter, unless you know**
- *What you want to do*
- *What you can offer*
- *What the company or program does*
- *What it can offer*

To find out what you want to do, consider the following:

- Your short-term and long-term goals
- Your previous training and interests
- Financial/geographical/personal advantages as well as constraints
- Technical person? Or Manager?
- Assessing previous training and interests

About the University/Institution/Company

- Information in the library/online resources/news media
- Company/University/Department publications, reviews of products, annual reports and so on
- If you know someone in the university/company, interview her/him
- Call someone in the personnel office or a manager in one of the technical departments

Designing the Letter/Email of Application

Only one page long and has four main sections

- **Heading**

1. A **first paragraph** which introduces you and then establishes the company's need
2. A **second paragraph** or series of paragraphs giving the ***most relevant*** experience and qualifications
3. A **closing paragraph** giving any other pertinent data
4. List of **Enclosures**

- **Balanced and visually attractive**

Designing the Resume

- Summary of all your activities and experience
- Repeats some/most of information in the letter of application
- Highlights your most important qualifications
- [Letter and Resume are separate]

Honors and Extra-Curricular Activities

- Command of other languages
- Technical/Software expertise
- Date on which you can start working
- Availability of references

References

- Make connections and contacts in advance
- They should have a fair and positive idea of your work and credentials
- Make sure to avoid a conflict of interest
- Either available on request or list your referees
- Better take her/his/their permission